

TABLE 2—IMMEDIATE ENROLLMENT IN POSTSECONDARY EDUCATION, BY TYPE OF INSTITUTION

	High quality				Low quality		
	Any	Any	Private	Public	Any	Private	Public
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
<i>Panel A. SABER 11 as the running variable</i>							
RF	0.32 (0.012)	0.465 (0.012)	0.466 (0.011)	0 (0.007)	−0.154 (0.011)	−0.063 (0.007)	−0.087 (0.009)
Mean control	0.37	0.109	0.033	0.075	0.267	0.105	0.159
Observations	299,475	299,475	299,475	299,475	299,475	299,475	299,475
BW loc. poly.	29.679	24.804	23.861	32.065	23.562	30.554	25.059
Effect obs. control	31,170	23,600	22,473	36,290	22,473	33,042	25,256
Effect obs. treat	11,711	10,641	10,442	12,264	10,442	11,953	10,927
<i>Panel B. SISBEN as the running variable</i>							
RF	0.274 (0.027)	0.396 (0.024)	0.477 (0.02)	−0.079 (0.018)	−0.12 (0.022)	−0.052 (0.015)	−0.076 (0.016)
Mean control	0.485	0.261	0.067	0.194	0.225	0.097	0.134
Observations	23,132	23,132	23,132	23,132	23,132	23,132	23,132
BW loc. poly.	9.028	10.954	12.224	11.604	8.05	9.176	10.329
Effect obs. control	3,868	4,604	5,043	4,854	3,488	3,964	4,392
Effect obs. treat	3,902	4,703	5,221	4,967	3,450	3,976	4,454

Notes: This table presents the effect of financial aid eligibility on immediate postsecondary enrollment using a regression discontinuity design. The dependent variable is immediate enrollment by type of postsecondary institution (e.g., high-quality, low-quality, private, public). Panel A uses SABER 11 test score as the running variable, restricting the sample to SISBEN-eligible students. Panel B uses SISBEN wealth index as the running variable, restricting the sample to SABER 11-eligible students. The reduced-form coefficient in column 1 of panel A suggests that, for individuals below a certain level of poverty, financial aid eligibility raises immediate postsecondary enrollment by 32.0 percentage points. On a basis of 37.0 percent, this implies an 86.5 percent increase in immediate enrollment. Bias-corrected RD results estimated with package *rdrobust* (Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik 2014). Robust standard errors in parentheses. These regressions exclude all baseline covariates. Online Appendix Table A.4 reproduces these reduced-form estimates and compares how the exclusion or inclusion of baseline covariates affects the reduced-form coefficient.

Source: Authors' calculations based on ICFES, DNP, MEN, and SPADIES.

the test score cutoff for sufficiently poor students; the corresponding reduced-form estimate is 27.4 percentage points (56.5 percent). As explained above, SISBEN-eligible individuals around the test score cutoff are significantly poorer and ex ante less likely to attend college than SABER 11-eligible individuals around the household wealth index: the control means are 37 percent versus 48.5 percent, respectively. As a result, financial aid has the largest enrollment impacts among low-income students whose test scores render them barely eligible for financial aid.¹⁷

The estimates in Table 2 could be confounded by an effect of passing the SABER 11 or SISBEN threshold that is not purely due to access to financial aid. This would be the case, for instance, if students were more likely to be offered college admission if they scored above the SABER 11 threshold, or if the SISBEN cutoff were correlated with other factors affecting college entry (e.g., other transfer programs). A way to detect this kind of bias is to perform a placebo test by running the same regression in the pre-period sample. Intuitively, in order for the RD

¹⁷We focus on the reduced-form estimates, which capture the effect of financial aid eligibility on the outcomes of interest. Insofar as need-based and merit-based eligibility represent financial aid offers (contingent on aid being used to study at a high-quality HEI), this answers the relevant policy question.